ships. They usually carried four to eight forward-firing guns and a number of smaller swivel guns in addition to oversized muskets and rockets.

In 1574, Akbar was accompanied on the river by a small party of his best officers, both Hindu and Muslim, including Raja Bhagwant Das, Man Singh, Birbal, Shahbaz Khan, and Qasim Khan, the mir bahr (admiral). When the party was finally ready to sail, the very face of the river was hidden by the huge number of boats. Banners were hoisted up the creaking masts as the clouds skidded across the sky and the monsoon winds began to gust. As the boats set sail, the watching fishermen let out such loud shouts and ululations that ‘the birds of the air and the fish of the water were well-nigh made to dance’.

The boats headed down the Yamuna towards Prayag and every day Akbar would call a halt for hunting and in the evening they would cast anchor and the party would be entertained by poetry recitations, singers, and other entertainments. Heroic deeds were recalled, musicians sang and banquets may have included Akbar’s favourite fruits—melons, grapes, and pomegranates which he enjoyed eating along with opium and wine. The mangoes cultivated in Hindustan were always the soft pulp variety, which would be squeezed in the hand and the pulp sucked out. (The Portuguese, needing firmer mangoes that could be cut for the table for consumption in Europe, had begun experimenting with grafts in Goa and had developed a new, fragrant, and firm variety which they named the Alphonso, in honour of Alfonso de Albuquerque, the man who had conquered Goa in 1510.) In the enchantment of these wind-swept evenings, Akbar was sometimes moved to tears by the touching pathos of the stories recited by the qissa-khwans.

Every day the storms grew fiercer and the boats struggled in the strong rain and the sudden wind. Many boats sank near Etawah and eleven more were lost at Ilahabas near Prayag, and the naqqar khana (orchestra) was damaged and nearly lost. Badauni noted about Prayag that this was where ‘the waters of the Ganga and Jumna unite. The infidels consider this a holy place and, with a desire to obtain the rewards which are promised in their creed…they submit themselves to all kinds of tortures’. Ralph Fitch, the English traveller, was equally bewildered and only marginally more sympathetic when he wrote that there were ‘many beggars in these countries which go naked, and the people make great account of them’. He wrote of naked sadhus with long beards, matted hair, and monstrous nails.